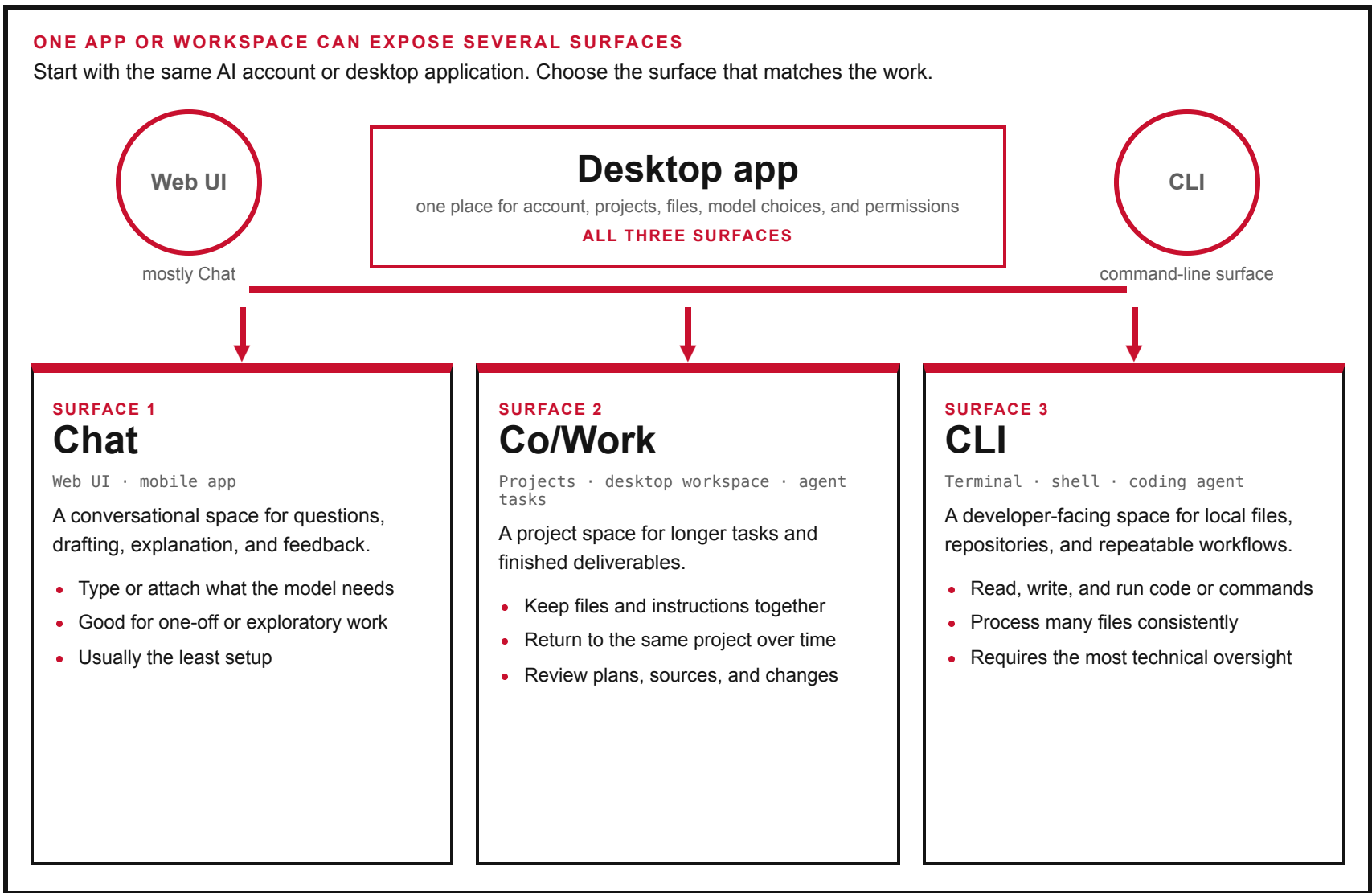


Three AI work surfaces

Web UI · Desktop app · CLI above; Chat · Co/Work · Code below

The **surface** is the environment where you work with an AI model. The model may be similar across surfaces; what changes is the context it can use, the actions it can take, and how much setup or oversight the task requires.



WHAT CHANGES AS YOU MOVE ACROSS SURFACES?

Chat: You provide the context in the conversation. Results usually stay in the chat until you copy them out.	Co/Work: A project can hold files, instructions, and task history. The AI can create deliverables for you to review.	CLI: The AI can operate on a repository or folder through tools. Changes can be repeated, tested, and reviewed as a diff.
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WHEN TO CHOOSE EACH ONE

- Brainstorming or drafting - Explaining a concept - Small, self-contained input	- Several related files - Multi-step research or writing - A deliverable to revise over time	- Many files or repeated runs - Software and data workflows - Tests, version control, or automation
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Surface, model, and permissions

The interface is only one part of the system

A product name does not tell you exactly what the AI can see or do. Check the model, connected data, tools, and approval settings for the particular account and task.

WHAT TO CHECK

MODEL • Which model is selected? • What are its limits for length, images, code, and reasoning? • Is the result important enough to verify against a source?	CONTEXT • Which messages, files, project notes, or connected apps are included? • Could sensitive information be in that context? • Can the model distinguish instructions from untrusted source text?	ACTIONS • Can it only suggest, or can it edit files and run commands? • Does it ask before taking a consequential action? • Can you inspect and undo the changes?
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PROVIDER EXAMPLES AT A GLANCE

OpenAI: ChatGPT provides Chat and project work in the current desktop experience; Codex is the coding surface. Availability depends on account and plan.	Anthropic: Claude provides browser chat; Cowork and Claude Code add project, desktop, or terminal-based work. Availability depends on account and plan.	Other providers: Gemini, Copilot, and other systems use different product names and combinations. Map their features to Chat, Co/Work, and CLI by checking what context and actions they support.
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PRACTICAL RULE

Use **Chat** when you need a conversation. Use the **desktop app** when you need a project and a deliverable. Use the **CLI** when you need a repeatable operation on files or software. In every surface, read the plan, inspect the source, and check the result.

Product names and availability change. This handout describes a comparison framework for the workshop; consult the provider's current documentation and your institution's policies before using connected data or granting permissions.